

WHY IS HE FIGHTING?

It is a battle that Bhairon Singh Shekhawat is unlikely to win. Then why is he risking such an illustrious political career? Inside the mind of the vice-president who won't give up.

SUMEET INDER SINGH

won as a result of the revolt by Indira Gandhi against the official candidate Neelam Sanjeeva Reddy. Morarji Desai's Janata government decided to sponsor Reddy instead of B.D. Jatti in 1977. More recently, vice-president Krishna Kant was bypassed for Kalam as there was no consensus on Kant. A politically paranoid UPA made no attempt at building a consensus before formally unveiling Patil.

As the contest gets dirtier, Shekhawat prefers to sound presidential, and portrays himself as the redeemer of Raisina Hill. "The nation should not have a rubber stamp as President. We are going through a very complex political environment now. The President should not sign every file and document without reading it and understanding its implications," he says. While conceding that the President is bound by the advice of the Council of Ministers and the will of the

Parliament, he argues that the President can play an important role in bringing an alternative or more views to the notice of the government. "The President is the guardian of the Constitution," he says. And his handlers never miss an opportunity to tell you that the nation cannot afford to have another President like Fakhruddin Ali Ahmed, immortalised by a cartoon that showed him signing the promulgation of the Emergency while reclining in his bath tub.

"I want to set a tradition. The vice-president should be the natural choice for the presidency."

B.S. SHEKHAWAT, VICE-PRESIDENT

Are these lofty ideals a camouflage for his lust for power? Isn't it time to take it easy, to sit at home and play with grandchildren? He is not amused. The apostle of an active presidency thinks the Rashtrapati Bhavan will give him a rare platform to play a larger constitutional as well as a social role. "The presidency can be more than ceremonial. It has a great potential to serve the real poor." The right to live with dignity is a fundamental right, he says, and those 260 million or more who live below the poverty line are denied dignity. "The President can nudge the government on a regular basis to formulate a real *garibi hatao* policy." He wants to be the guardian of the nation. "That is the real role of the President."

Confounding the political calculator, he gives himself a very high chance of winning that most coveted role in national life. The war-scarred veteran, though, won't reveal his strategy, except saying: "I will not ask for votes. I will not visit any state. My work and my well wishers will get me the votes." His confidence, obviously, stems from his all-party appeal and his legendary friendship with leaders of different political hues. Apparently, the UPA is secretly worried about the possibility of a voting along caste lines—there are enough Thakur legislators out there who have the clout to swing a large number of votes for Hukum.

At the moment, however towering he may be, Shekhawat is fighting the battle of a lifetime—and it is getting dirtier. His stature may be matched by his moral vigour, his charisma by his fighting spirit, but this presidential election is hardly an honourable contest. Political Delhi is inundated with pamphlets of perfidies, and one of anonymous authorship is titled "Vice-President Bhairon Singh Shekhawat: Bhismpitamha of Corruption". UPA has suddenly realised that the only way to overcome the embarrassment of the Pratibha Patil candidacy is to try hard to take some sheen out of the formidable Thakur. Shekhawat may not win the presidency, he wants to win the moral battle. For certain men, life at 83 is not about savouring the sunset in the sandy remoteness of Rajasthan. Hukum is not scared of losing. He knows there is honour in defeat too. ■